ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

AI Tools for Studying: Use Them Without Cheating Yourself

Where AI genuinely helps learning, and where it quietly damages your degree

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

AI tools are useful tutors and dangerous shortcuts. This pack explains what they do well, where they confidently produce wrong answers, how to write prompts that produce checkable output, and how to stay within your department's integrity rules.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Use AI for explanation, practice and feedback rather than submission.
- Write prompts that specify context, level and output format.
- Verify AI output against reliable sources and detect fabricated references.
- Apply your department's rules on disclosure and permitted use.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What AI is good at

Treat AI as an explainer and practice partner, not an author.

- Re-explaining a concept at a simpler level until you understand it.
- Generating practice questions on a topic you specify.
- Critiquing your own draft for structure and clarity.
- Producing examples and analogies you then verify.
- Summarising a document you already have, as a first pass only.
- Translating and checking grammar in your own writing.

What it gets wrong

Language models produce plausible text, not verified truth.

- Fabricated references, statistics and quotations.
- Confident errors in calculations and niche local detail.
- Outdated information on current events, policies and prices.
- Bias and oversimplification on contested topics.
- Generic writing that sounds like nobody in particular.
- Hidden errors when you lack the knowledge to check the answer.

> **The verification rule**
> If you cannot check a claim yourself, do not submit it. A citation you have not opened is not a source.

Prompting and integrity

Better prompts produce more checkable answers.

- State your level, the course, the length and the required format.
- Ask for step-by-step explanation rather than the final answer.
- Request sources, then verify each one independently.
- Ask it to identify weaknesses in your argument, not to write the argument.
- Disclose AI assistance where your department requires it.
- Never use AI where it is prohibited; an acknowledgement does not make a prohibited act allowed.

What these tools are good at, and what they are not

Language models generate plausible text by predicting what usually follows. That makes them useful for explaining a concept in simpler words, generating practice questions, suggesting structures, and checking your grammar. It also makes them capable of confident invention - fabricated citations, wrong dates, non-existent laws - which is why every factual claim must be verified.

The distinction that matters is between using a tool to think and using it to avoid thinking. Asking for an explanation of a concept you then test yourself on is study. Asking for an essay you submit as your own is misconduct, regardless of how much you edit it.

Assume your institution will detect and penalise undisclosed use. Disclosure rules vary, so read your department's policy and, when unsure, ask before submitting.

Uses that genuinely help

Explanation at a different level: ask for a simpler explanation, an analogy, or a counter-example. Then close the tool and write the explanation yourself; if you cannot, you have not learned it.

Practice generation: ask for ten exam-style questions on a named topic, answer them closed-book, then compare with your notes. The questions are only as good as your ability to check the answers, so use topics you know well enough to judge.

Editing and structure: ask for feedback on clarity, or for three possible outlines for an argument you have already researched. Never let a tool supply the evidence - that is the part you must find and cite.

> **Verify or omit**
> Any citation, statistic, date or quotation a tool gives you must be checked against the original source before it appears in your work. Unverified generated citations are the commonest form of accidental fabrication.

Risk, privacy and academic honesty

Do not paste confidential material - other people's data, unpublished research, personal information - into a public tool. Assume anything you enter may be stored and reviewed.

Keep a record of how you used a tool if your department requires disclosure: which tool, what prompt, what you did with the output. Honest disclosure is almost always treated more leniently than concealment.

The professional parallel is worth remembering: using a tool for a first draft is normal in many workplaces, but signing your name to work you cannot defend is not. Your qualification certifies your capability, and that is what an employer or a postgraduate panel will test.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Using a tool to study a hard concept

You do not understand the difference between validity and soundness.

1. Ask the tool for a simple explanation with two examples.
2. Read it once and close it.
3. Write your own explanation from memory.
4. Test yourself with three new examples you invent.
5. Check your answers against your textbook, not against the tool.
6. Note the one point you still cannot explain and ask a lecturer.

> **What to carry forward**
> The tool is a first reader, not an authority. Your textbook and your lecturer are the check.

2. Checking a generated citation

A tool gives you: "Achebe, C. (1958) Things Fall Apart. London: Heinemann." plus a page reference.

1. Verify the book exists and the publication details match a library catalogue.
2. Check the edition you are using, because page numbers differ between editions.
3. Locate the quoted passage yourself.
4. If you cannot find it, do not cite it.
5. Cite the edition you actually consulted.
6. If the claim came from the tool rather than the book, do not use the claim.

> **What to carry forward**
> Publication details may be right while the quotation is invented. Check the passage, not just the book.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish using an AI tool to support learning from using it to commit academic misconduct.

15 marks

1. Support: explanation, practice questions, feedback on your own work.
2. Misconduct: submitting generated text as your own, undisclosed.
3. The test is whether the thinking and evidence are yours.
4. Institutional disclosure rules determine what must be declared.

Q2. Why must every factual claim from a language model be verified?

10 marks

1. Models predict plausible text rather than retrieving verified facts.
2. Fabricated citations and confident errors occur.
3. Verification against primary sources is the only check.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Language model. A system that generates text by predicting likely sequences.

Hallucination. Confident output that is factually wrong or invented.

Prompt. The instruction given to a generative tool.

Disclosure. Declaring how a tool was used in producing work.

Verification. Checking a claim against an authoritative source.

Primary source. The original document or data, as opposed to commentary.

Data protection. Rules governing the handling of personal information.

Attribution. Identifying the source of an idea, quotation or image.

Plagiarism. Presenting another's work or words as your own.

Critical evaluation. Judging the reliability of a source or output before using it.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Rules

Policy.

- Read your department's AI policy.
- Note disclosure requirements.
- List prohibited uses.

Week 2 - Study use

Explanation.

- Ask for a simpler explanation of one concept.
- Rewrite it from memory.
- Test yourself and note gaps.

Week 3 - Verify

Checking.

- Verify three generated citations.
- Find one fabricated detail.
- Practise locating the original passage.

Week 4 - Reflect

Honesty.

- Write a disclosure statement template.
- Review your own recent work for unverified claims.
- Ask a lecturer one clarifying question.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your institution's academic integrity and AI use policy.
- A guide to source verification for students.
- A critical thinking text on evaluating evidence.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name three legitimate study uses of AI.

Answer: Explaining a concept, generating practice questions and giving feedback on your draft.

2. Why are AI-generated references risky?

Answer: Models can fabricate plausible-looking citations that do not exist or do not say what is claimed.

3. Write a useful prompt for studying a topic.

Answer: For example: 'Explain photosynthesis to a 100-level biology student in 250 words with one worked example, then give me five practice questions with answers.'

4. What should you do if your department prohibits AI use?

Answer: Do not use it for that assessment; follow the policy even if you believe disclosure would be honest.

5. How can AI damage your learning?

Answer: By replacing the retrieval and reasoning practice that builds durable knowledge, leaving you unable to perform in examinations.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read your department's policy on AI use.
- [ ] Write three prompts that request explanation, not answers.
- [ ] Verify five AI-generated facts against a textbook or official site.
- [ ] Check every cited source by opening it.
- [ ] Use AI to critique one of your own drafts.
- [ ] Complete one assignment with no AI assistance to test your own ability.
- [ ] Record when and how you used AI for transparency.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Digital Skills | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: